

God's Sufficient Grace

Turn to 2 Corinthians 12, kind of where I left off, in case I make it back.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

I did not know the path I was setting myself on in Oregon those years ago when I began to pray. God knows the only reason I switched the volume of my praying to tongues was for lack of things to say.

Everybody had a different opinion about it. Some said, "You cannot do it anytime you want." Others said, "It is edification." Okay, but if it edifies you, then you receive some kind of charge. It builds you up on your most holy faith. Although nobody could really explain why, except that you were receiving some kind of charge.

Little did I know it would open up truth. If you are going to be built up on your most holy God-kind of faith, then faith comes by hearing and hearing by the Word. I did not know the path it would put me on would be a path of revelation. Even less did I know it would be a collision path with religion.

In the collision path with religion, little did I know the price that would be paid. He has been bringing me back to Paul's thorn. Even if I wanted to get into something else, I cannot when that is what is churning up.

I do know this: what Paul knew about grace, I needed to know to survive. The only thing he was guilty of was revelation knowledge. In fact, his whole assignment from the devil was because of the abundance of his revelation.

The devil knew the best way to stop a flood is to somehow turn the fountain off. If you can kill the source, you will not have to worry about the result.

In the first years I blindly prayed and did not know where revelation knowledge was coming from. Now I do know. When it came time to put the worship limb on, the devil knew that would be the time he had to move on me. If I was going to believe anything else besides the Word of God, he had to move then. At that point he did.

That is probably tied in with the same angels that transform as angels of light. They come as God. They do not come with darkness. They come acting as God. By no small miracle, I survived. I think I prayed my way out of it before I got into it. So when I went into it, the path opened out of it.

He who searches the heart knows what is the mind of God and makes intercession for the saints according to the will of God. Then we can know all things work together for good to them that love God and are called according to the overall purpose of God.

I am glad I can work my future on purpose. I have not always done it right, but I recover quickly and keep working it.

It seems that the same bunch of angels was staging the takeout on that level: "If we can turn the fountain off on that level, and then do some seduction along the way, we can use this guy."

Paul said:

The weapons of our warfare are not carnal, but mighty through God to the pulling down of strong holds.

This weapon we are supposed to wield is mighty through God to the pulling down of strongholds. Then he gives the definition of strongholds and the three takeouts that follow:

Casting down imaginations, and every high thing that exalteth itself against the knowledge of God, and bringing into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ.

An imagination is a system of thought empowered by emotion.

There is only one way the devil can defeat you: he has to get you to do it yourself. You have already been given power over all his power. The way he can defeat you is to keep you from knowing that.

The power of this weapon can pull down imaginations, empowered systems of thought and emotion, out of my life. Why? Because if he can deceive me, he can defeat me.

"Every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God, bringing into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ." Why? Because you are where the deciding factor is fought. You are the battleground. If you believe it, you win. If you do not, you lose. You are the battleground.

So he has to play by those rules whether he likes it or not. He has to get you to defeat yourself.

No, thank you. I believe I will not do that.

Hallelujah.

Have you ever wondered what happened in the garden when it came time for Satan's judgment because of his intrusion? He fell long, long before we did. Jesus said he was a liar from the beginning. It could not be the devil's beginning, because he was perfect in his ways when he was created. If he is a liar from the beginning, then it has to be from the beginning of our creation. We know that is how he entered into the garden, and it was an intrusion.

He got judged. In that judgment, he was reduced an entire level of authority from what he had walked in.

Do you understand what an archangel can do? They could probably destroy a world like this one, but not unless they were at full power.

When you read the account of what happened, he had to use imagery of one kind or another. "The serpent was more subtle than any beast of the field." What kind of talk is that? Have you ever leaned over a fence and had a conversation with Nellie Bell the cow? Not lately.

God said in Satan's judgment that he would eat the dust of the earth. People say, "That is where the serpent came from, no arms." Well, what did he have before that? Was he standing there and all of a sudden his arms fell off?

When I get to this part, sometimes I cannot help it. A known teacher was teaching, "I can tell you what happened to Eve. She was so taken back by a talking snake that when he offered her the apple, she just took it." I thought he was kidding.

What it was, was a reduction in his authority. When God said, "You are reduced to eat the dust of the earth," that is where we came from. What He was really saying was, "You cannot devastate with the power of an archangel. You are not going to throw people off cliffs and kill them deliberately one on one. The only thing you are going to be able to operate in now is what they let you operate in, and that is on the level of the flesh."

He comes, and he has to get you to do it. No wonder Paul said the mighty weapons of God pull down those kinds of stronghold systems of thought powered by emotion, telling you how inadequate you are, how this never works for you, how the Word does not work for you, all that same old song he sings.

I have good news for you: Paul had to find all that out because he would not vary or compromise the Word. So he had to take Satan on and everything Satan had to throw at him to stop him. It took three times, but at the end he got it.

He needed the grace to win when the weakness was predominant in everything we are as human beings. He still won because he found something out about grace.

Casting down imaginations is a weapon of God. Pulling down every high thing that exalts itself against the knowledge of God is a weapon. Bringing every thought down to our level, the thought level, into the obedience of Christ is a weapon.

Why? We were in darkness, the earth scheduled for termination, walking dead men born to die. That was the condition we were in on the other side of God, lost in darkness. Even if He wanted to save us, He had nothing to save us with. What could He come over and save us with?

Until Jesus crossed the void of spiritual death, and to do that He had to become one of us.

I like how He words it:

I am the way, the truth, and the life: no man cometh unto the Father, but by me.

He is the way. He is the truth. He is the life you receive. No man comes to the Father but by Him, because there is no other path. He is the way, the truth, and the life that you end up with. He is the culmination of all of it.

I am finding out now that the path to the cross is as sovereign, final, and finished as the cross itself. Why would He provide a miracle for me and then give me a haphazard path, different every time I try to walk it, with new sets of rules that throw me off all the time?

No. He is the way.

Is there any other truth? We were locked up outside of God, on the other side of spiritual death, with no way back. He is the way back. He is the truth along the way. He is the life you receive.

No man can come to the Father but by Him. There is no other source of knowledge. There is no other contact. There is no other way. He is it. He is the truth.

Will the truth work? What do you think? Is there really a way to receive everything the cross provided? What do you think? Is there really this life back in God? Oh, yes.

When the Teacher gets hold of people, He is going to bring you to a place of war. One thing you will have to keep in mind is this: His grace is sufficient.

The devil already tried the neutralization by seduction, and that did not work. Now he is trying the war.

Finally, I understood our call to Japan. He spoke to me about two nations way back, fifteen years ago. One was Brazil, and they remember the word I gave them: that I would never stop. The other was Japan.

I thought, "Japan? That is interesting. Good thing I can hear God or I would not have believed it."

I was born in 1943. By 1950 I was working on stuff, and tools you could get would say, "Made in Japan." You could get a whole set of screwdrivers for a quarter. Trouble is, the screw would bend the screwdriver. Pliers would fold. You would go to turn something and the nut would strip the pliers. The hammer would flatten out instead of the nail.

Do you know what they did? They are a rock out in the ocean with no resources to speak of. Everything they get, they have to import and export. Yet they manufactured these tools, flooded us with them, and everybody was buying them. They salvaged themselves.

Japan buys whole mountains of iron ore from Brazil. They take this iron ore and pay pennies for it, then put it into silicon chips and little electronic parts. They import very cheaply and export very expensively. They live on a rock with no resources.

What kind of people are they? Pretty soon, "made in Japan" changed. Now if you want a good car, you get one of theirs, and we had to get on the ball to keep up, because they did not stay underachieving. They were surviving.

Those consecrated, dedicated people in their day, single-minded with purpose. What do you think could happen if a real revival went to that rock? I am talking about signs and wonders, raising the dead, emptying hospitals. Then they want to know, "How can I do this?"

Look out, world.

Singleness of mind and purpose. If we do not get on the ball here, they may have a revival there, learn about this prayer, then a team will come over here and win Tulsa. If they employ the singleness of mind and purpose they have employed in everything else, then in the last days they are going to play a forefront role in the raging revival that is going to sweep.

Here we are, sitting on all this truth. Boy, has He balanced it for me. I am understanding more and more all the time what makes it right. The further I get into it, the more I know that He loves you. I know that He loves you. I know He loves me.

It is not the imbalanced kind that ends up with everybody being saved. That was another takeout. Five levels. Satan comes to steal what? The Word. What do you think he was after that Paul had?

He used persecution, affliction, the cares of this life, and the fourth level, the deceitfulness of riches. Not the riches themselves, the deceitfulness of them. Finally, the last level is the lust for other things. That one is the god complex, lust for power, self-exaltation.

That is where I learned that self-exaltation can be more addictive than cocaine. Once people have it, they will almost do anything to keep it. I call it the god complex. It is the deception that turns out all the special callings and all the Elijahs to come: "I am special. I am special. God has something special for me."

Wrong. Wrong.

When I find out how much He loved you, then I know.

"I do not feel like it. He never takes time with me. He never spends time with me. He does not use me or anything. I do not feel anything."

Remember this: you are always going to be somewhere. We are here working on you to make sure it is the right place, and you will go there. He will go there with something.

This world is scheduled for termination. There is not much else in His mind except that you are all eternal creatures. God cannot get people from anywhere else. Unless a man is born of flesh and of the Spirit, he will not enter the kingdom of God. You have to have the two births. One was when you came into existence, and the second was when you received His life.

Every baby who comes into existence is going to live somewhere forever. You are an eternal creature. This planet is not. The elements will pass away with fervent heat and a great noise, and all the works there will be burned up. We will be in front of the great white throne at that time. We will not feel anything like that. When we go back, it will be to a new heaven and a new earth.

You outlived this one. You will outlive that one. How do you think He looks at you? As something temporary to discard or not take time with? What?

Do you think He does not hear you because you are insignificant? Do you not know He uses words like, "You are a new creation," because you are something?

The only way the devil can defeat you is to give you the worm complex. Religion sure does a good job on that. You end up believing that you are nothing and He is out of reach. That is a lie that will defeat you.

Here is the reward:

| All that will live godly in Christ Jesus shall suffer persecution.

Why? Because there is a maniac being terminated at the same time our planet and our change of life are coming: spirit, soul, glorified body. But he has certain rights now.

Why did God not terminate him sooner? Obviously He could not and remain who He is. He does not do these things for you to suffer. He has no other recourse or change, and He cannot change. So He has to make things work around them until He can enter into them.

Why did He not stop Satan? Theologians say He needed to prove humanity. He does not play sick games like that. He does not play sick games with a perfectly good creation.

"Well, we had to be tried to see if we were worthy of our free moral agency."

No. I would much rather have grown from the day of my creation and survived hell than be part of a plot of some maniac that God is using to perfect me.

You can rest assured in the attributes that define God. He cannot change. The attribute of immutability means He cannot change, nor can He be changed, because there is nothing higher than Him that can change Him. But you can trust Him because He will always be the same. You may have fallen away, but when you come back, you will find Him the same, and the answer will be the same, and so will the victory.

Why did we fall and it take four thousand years to get Him into the earth, and two thousand more after that? Why is He waiting? Why did He not harvest this sooner? Why did He not stop the devil at the entry level?

In the definition of His character, there are some things He cannot do and some things He can.

Here is a good defining statement of God. When I said this in Brazil, I said, "The most costly thing heaven ever sustained was the right to choose."

We only have two creations to look at, the angelic and ours, and we both fell. A third of the angels were lost, supposedly. How many human beings? We cannot count.

So what is it? Is He sick, or is there something we have to have that He esteems so highly that He is willing to pay whatever it costs Him to have the fellowship you can give Him for the rest of eternity?

It cost heaven everything just for the right of me to lift my hands and worship God and be received because I choose. What was He after that He esteemed so highly that He was willing to pay such a horrendous cost to even move on with creation?

He paid it. I have the right to choose. He is the way. He is the truth. He is the life. I choose Him every foot of the way, and hell is going to pay.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

The further I get into this, the more I understand how He loves you. You are an eternal creature. You are going to be around forever. Do you think He does not listen when you talk? You were lost and elected to serve Him. Do you mean He is holding Himself off at a distance from you when there will never be a time you are not here?

No. I have to learn what Paul knew on the third round with the grace he asked God for.

Not only does Satan assault directly, here is one of the real reasons Paul never married, whether they like it or not. They are elected for the war and become part of the chess game to stop you.

Looking at how the devil works and looking at what Paul said, "Should I marry? Then I will care for the things of her, what she wants and what pleases her. Should I not marry and spend days and nights in the deep, getting beaten all the time, whipped, my feet broken, left to die? Let me see. Marriage? I think I will take the thorn. Shipwrecks, beatings, stripes, punishment, stoned, whipped, the care of the churches on me daily, or a raven beauty? I think I will take the thorn."

My family did not ask for mine. They did not ask to come under the same mantle, but they do. Once you answer the call and get as far as we are getting, the devil also tries to drag them underneath the bar, put pressure on them, break them down, to break you down.

I heard a preacher tell me one time, "When I quit, it all stopped."

Yes, right. Because of the abundance of my revelations, Paul said, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh, a messenger of Satan to buffet me, lest I be exalted above measure.

He was saying, "You do not have to worry about me being exalted like you guys. You do not have to worry about that. I am not going to rule as a king like you. I am preaching the truth, and it has to be stopped."

My family has been through a lot, but they are surviving. He has tried to kill all of them a few times. We are going to see this through. I would be foolish to turn back now.

How do you feel? Great.

What are you having experiences with? "My peace I give unto you." That is not of this world. No kidding. It is really not.

Perfect love casts out fear. What kind of character are you if you walk with no fear? Oh, for crying out loud. That is what other people would do: cry out loud.

Hallelujah. To walk with no fear. What do you have to be afraid of? Paul faced everything in three graces. Yes, he had to be weak. Some of those areas were challenged, and he had to be weak, because in his weakness, what came forward?

We need to read this, do we not?

Second Corinthians 12:1:

It is not expedient for me doubtless to glory. I will come to visions and revelations of the Lord.

I knew a man in Christ above fourteen years ago...

Whether in the body, I cannot tell; whether out of the body, I cannot tell. God knows. Such a one was caught up to the third heaven.

He says it again:

And I knew such a man, (whether in the body, or out of the body, I cannot tell: God knoweth;)

How that he was caught up into paradise, and heard unspeakable words, which it is not lawful for a man to utter.

Of such an one will I glory: yet of myself I will not glory, but in mine infirmities.

Is that not interesting?

For though I would desire to glory, I shall not be a fool...

I will say the truth, but now I forbear. I will pass, lest any man should think of me above that which he sees me to be or hears of me.

And lest I should be exalted above measure through the abundance of the revelations, there was given to me a thorn in the flesh...

Now I have to stop here for a minute and reflect on what I told you two services in a row. Your finest minds try to come to a conclusion about what the thorn is. I will give you those three again.

The first, most common, is his eyes. He was going blind, and that is why he wrote such a big letter with his own hand. You know, big letters.

The second is just hilarious: epilepsy. He obviously had a seizure on the road to Damascus.

Third, some form of malaria or fever and sickness that he fought all the time.

I would say we need some Word. We need a revival of doctrine, would you not say?

I am not in Disneyland. I am not a dreamer that way. But I can see some of our guys really playing a part in a revival of doctrine in the last days.

How is the devil most successful? He takes your rights away by getting you not to believe them. What would you do with somebody who kept churning out revelation knowledge like Paul? He warranted a special assignment.

Paul said:

There was given to me a thorn in the flesh, the messenger of Satan to buffet me...

For this thing I besought the Lord thrice, that it might depart from me.

And he said unto me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness.

Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my infirmities, not for them, but in the midst of them for who He is, that the power of Christ might rest on me.

He took it a step further:

Therefore I take pleasure in infirmities...

You might say, "Well, he takes pleasure because of the infirmities. He enjoys these things." No, he did not. If he enjoyed them, he would not have sought God three times for them to depart from him.

But he learned something about grace. No matter what happened, he and his own emotions and spirit could maintain a place of joy and great pleasure in God for what God had done about all those weaknesses with His grace.

Now you are talking about a lot of faith. Waiting to die the next morning, ship sinking, going to get beaten again. Three times Paul said, "I sought God," and God said, "My strength is perfected in your weakness."

What He was saying was, "My grace is sufficient. If My strength is being perfected in your weaknesses, then there must be some weaknesses there for it to be perfected in."

The kind Paul was talking about, by the time the third one in particular came, was not mostly the temptation for the flesh, lusts, money, or those kinds of things. You can see what he did with money. In fact, they were mad at him. He said, "Did I do you wrong by working with my hands and being accountable for myself?"

The weakness he was talking about was not the lusts of the flesh or temptations to do wrong. It was when they were going to kill him in the morning, beat him again, break the bones in his feet again, things out of his control. No matter how strong he was in the natural, there was nothing he could do about those things.

He came to the place where he could take great joy and pleasure in the presence of God, even though he was facing death by morning or another beating. He said, "When I am weak, unable to perform this thing in my own strength, You are strong, because grace is telling me the cross is enough."

There is a place of not worrying. It would be a new feeling for some. Hallelujah.

Should we continue this? The whole thing He wanted you to know is this: His grace is sufficient.

It does not matter how unable you are to do anything about it, if you employed everything you had and all the strength you have. There is nothing stronger than Him being totally turned loose in your life. Nothing.

Perfect love casts out fear. You love Him, though not as much as He loves you.

I do not have to wait until I see Him deliver me four or five times. Paul told me what would happen. I do not need to be delivered; I just need to know what to do.

Are you quiet?

Three times: "God, please. Can You see how bad it is? I am probably going to die by morning. If they do not kill me, this storm is going to kill us. Please, can You not do something?"

"My grace is sufficient."

That is a real good way of saying, "I already have. You just have to believe it."

I can tell you a good start: take great joy worshiping Him, speaking out loud what His Word said about your problem.

I think I can almost truly say that when I worship Him, I do know He is going to do something. That is taking pleasure and great joy. I do know He is going to do something. I cannot say that I do not. That was the frame of mind Paul put you in when you went into the thing.

But I am getting where I can say this: I really am beginning to worship Him not because I need any proof, not because I know what He can do and I am trying to get Him to do it. I really can worship Him because I know now that I love Him because He loved me first. I am worshiping Him and glorifying Him because He loves me.

I already know what I have to worship Him for to get free, when I already know I am.

I am going to tell Him I love Him because I do. So I take great joy, and I take pleasure in distresses, perplexities, necessities, and any other hellstorm he wants to throw at me. Because when he strips me of my dependency on the flesh, watch out, devil, because it switches on the

Spirit.

And I am strong.